

MARCELO GANTIER-MITA

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Economics, Political Economy, Environmental Economics.

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics

2022-2027 (*expected*)

Paris School of Economics

Advisor: Professor Karen Macours

Thesis committee member: Professor Oliver Vanden Eynde

Visiting PhD Student

Sept. 2025-April 2026

Vancouver School of Economics, University of British Columbia

Host: Professor Claudio Ferraz

Master in Public Policy and Development, with *summa cum laude*

2022

Paris School of Economics

Advisor: Professor Karen Macours

MSc. in Economics, with *Distinction*

2019

The University of Warwick

Advisor: Professor James Fenske

B.A. in Economics

2011-2015

Bolivian Catholic University (UCB)

WORKING PAPERS

· “Bringing Services Closer to People? Distance to Administrators and the Reach of the State”

(*Job Market Paper*, draft available upon request) [Policy Brief] [Blog Post]

Abstract: As populations grow, extending the reach of the state to a larger and more dispersed population becomes increasingly challenging. Many developing countries have responded by creating new subnational administrative units, bringing local administrators physically closer to citizens. Leveraging an episode of district proliferation in Uganda, this paper studies whether geographical proximity to local government administrative centers improves access to public goods and services and changes citizens’ engagement with government. To establish causality, I exploit a policy implementation rule that generated exogenous variation in households’ proximity to new district headquarters. Households living closer to these centers have significantly better access to electricity, roads, health facilities, and water sources. Proximity also shifts engagement from contentious to participatory channels and reduces direct experiences of corruption. Despite these gains, proximity does not increase trust in government or improve democratic perceptions, including in politically aligned districts where engagement effects are stronger. Finally, each district split raises transfers to the pre-split district territory by roughly 14 percent, with most of the increase concentrated in administrative expenditures rather than service delivery budgets.

· “Bottom-up Conservation: Sub-national Protected Areas and Local Governance in Bolivia” (with Julia Girard, Carlos Quezada-Lambertín and Jean Paul Benavides) (*draft available upon request*)

Abstract: Protected areas are central to global conservation policy, yet evidence on decentralized forest conservation remains limited. This paper studies Municipal Protected Areas in Bolivia, where municipalities can designate protected areas but the central government retains authority over rural land titling. Combining annual land cover data, parcel-level titling records, and judicial rulings, we examine whether local protection holds when the level of government that declares it does not control property rights over the same land. Using staggered difference-in-differences methods, we find that municipal protected areas modestly improve forest outcomes, reducing deforestation and the conversion of forest to pasture. In protected areas without indigenous territories, however, national titling increases after designation and shifts toward commercial and medium-sized properties, whose titling is followed by higher deforestation. This response is absent where protection overlaps indigenous territories.

- “Democratization of Justice and Checks and Balances in Bolivia”

Abstract: In 2011, Bolivia became the first country to select its highest court judges by popular vote, aiming to democratize justice and strengthen judicial legitimacy. This paper studies whether the reform affected the courts’ capacity to check the executive. Using the universe of high-court rulings since 2000, I compare outcomes in politically sensitive cases before and after the reform in a difference in differences setting. Preliminary findings suggest that, after the reform, the constitutional court became more likely to rule in favor of the government in cases where political power is directly at stake, including removal from office and electoral disputes. In the criminal chamber of the supreme court, appeals filed by accused public officials became more likely to be admitted and to succeed. These patterns are not present before the reform and become stronger under the second cohort of elected judges. Taken together, the evidence suggests that the popular election of judges, combined with government control over candidate pre-selection, may have facilitated political capture rather than strengthened checks and balances.

WORK IN PROGRESS

- “Turkish Soap Operas and Intimate Partner Violence in Peru”
- “Livestock Intensification, Structural Transformation, and Environmental Spillovers” (with Matthew Gordon, Karen Macours and Antonia Marcheva)
- “Building Skills in Agri-Food Systems: A Meta-Analysis of Extension and Training Programs” (with Karen Macours, Balasai Vanukuri and Amit Khanal)
- “Impact of Land Tenure on Tropical Working Lands” (with Daniela Miteva, Subhrendu Pattanayak, Erin Sills, Alex Pfaff, Allen Blackman, et al.)
- “An Unlikely Shield: Informal Settlements and Political Violence in Peru” (with Hector Paredes)

POLICY REPORTS

- “Measuring Livestock: A Review of Data Gaps and Methodological Opportunities for Livestock Data Collection in Household and Agricultural Surveys”, August 2025.

PRE-DOCTORAL PUBLICATIONS

Papers in Refereed Journals

- “Subjective Expectations and Schooling Choices in Latin America and the Caribbean” (with Andrea Repetto and Rafael Novella) *Journal of International Development*, 36(3), 1593-1621, 2024.
- “The effect of Government Expenditure on the Economy of Bolivia: an analysis of the 1990-2015 period” (with Germán Molina), *Revista Perspectivas No. 39*, May 2017 (*In Spanish*).

Working Papers

- “Commodity Shocks, Factor Intensity and Conflicts in Africa”, *IISEC Working Papers series 6/20*, November 2020 (*based on my MSc dissertation, University of Warwick*).
- “The Challenge of Tracking the Reach of Post-Green Revolution Crop Breeding” (with James Stevenson, Greg Traxler, Frederic Kosmowski, and Karen Macours), June 2023.

Book Chapters

- “Rent-seeking in a High Natural Resources Dependency Environment: The case of Bolivia” (with Bernardo Fernández y Martín Palmero) in Research for Bolivian Economic Development, *Academia Boliviana de Ciencias Economicas - Fundación INESAD*, Pag. 169-228, 2019 (*In Spanish*). [Working paper version] [Media coverage]
- “The relationship between natural resources and local human development: A blessing or a curse?” in Growth Inequality and the Challenge for sustainability (with Horacio Vera), *Konrad Adenauer Stiftung*, Pag. 141-156, 2018.

- Towards sustainable development in the Andean Region (with Fernanda Wanderley, Horacio Vera, Jean Paul Benavides and Karen Martinez), *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)*, 2018 (*In Spanish*).

Policy Reports

- “Social Debt in Bolivia” (Fernanda Wanderley and Jaime Perez coordinators), *Institute of Socio Economic Research*, July 2017 (*In Spanish*).

EXTERNAL PRESENTATIONS

- 2027:** ASSA Annual Meeting 2027 (AEA poster session)*
- 2026:** STEG Annual Conference (Nairobi), PacDev 2026 (UC, Davis), Dev/PE internal seminar VSE-UBC, AFÉPOP 2026 (Strasbourg University), Nordic Conference on Development Economics (Linnaeus University), International Conference in Development Economics (AFEDEV - Rouen University), 2nd Junior Workshop on Economics of Latin America (Berlin School of Economics), Oxford Development Economics Workshop (OxDev) 2026, Bruneck Workshop on Political Economy*
- 2025:** Applied Research Workshop (Bolivian Catholic University)
- 2024:** EPD Jamboree (Pompeu Fabra University), 2nd Essex PhD Conference in Applied Economics 12th Warwick Economics PhD Conference, Monthly Seminar Series Makerere University, Bolivian Conference on Development Economics (15th BCDE)
- 2023:** International Conference in Development Economics (AFEDEV - Paris School of Economics), Bolivian Conference on Development Economics (14th BCDE)

*Scheduled

RESEARCH GRANTS

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|--------------|---|------------|
| 2025: | Paris School of Economics, Mobility Grant | EUR 6,000 |
| | Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne, Mobility Grant | EUR 3,000 |
| | CNRS-PSE Development Group, <i>Democratization of Justice</i> | EUR 1,000 |
| 2024: | CNRS-PSE Development Group, <i>Bottom-up Conservation</i> | EUR 1,500 |
| | Agence Nationale de la Recherche EUR-PgSE, <i>Turkish Soap Operas</i> | EUR 2,500 |
| | CNRS-PSE Development Group, <i>Livestock Measurement</i> | EUR 1,000 |
| | International Growth Centre (IGC), <i>Job Market Paper</i> | GBP 4,135 |
| | Agence Nationale de la Recherche EUR-PgSE, <i>Job Market Paper</i> | EUR 4,000 |
| 2018: | CAF / A.B.C.E. / INESAD, <i>Rent-seeking in Bolivia</i> | USD 12,500 |

AWARDS AND DISTINCTIONS

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| Doctoral Contract ED 465 (Paris 1 Pantheon-Sorbonne) | 2022 |
| Recipient of a Full Scholarship to study at The Paris School of Economics | |
| Master PPD Scholarship (Paris School of Economics) | 2021 |
| Recipient of a Partial Scholarship to study at The Paris School of Economics | |
| Chevening Scholarship (Foreign and Commonwealth Office - UK) | 2018 |
| Recipient of a Full Scholarship to study at The University of Warwick | |
| IISEC-UCB Scholarship for the Summer School “Multidimensional Poverty” | 2017 |
| Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative (OPHI), University of Oxford | |
| National Award for the Best Undergraduate Dissertation in Economics | 2016 |
| Central Bank of Bolivia, 9th Bolivian Economists’ Forum | |

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Econometrics II: Treatment Effect Models 2023-24, 2024-25
Master in Public Policy and Development, Paris School of Economics
Best Teaching Assistant Award, Master PPD, academic year 2023/2024

Lecturer, Macroeconomics II 2020
Bolivian Catholic University

Lecturer, General Economics (Econ 101) 2017-2018
Bolivian Catholic University

Teaching Assistant, Econometrics I & II (2014-2015), Macroeconomics I (2013-2014), General Economics (2012)
Bolivian Catholic University

Short courses: Multidimensional Poverty Measurement (Bolivian Catholic University, 2017); Introduction to Stata Programming (Universidad Mayor de San Andrés, 2016); Household Surveys and Applications in Stata (Bolivian Catholic University, 2016).

PREVIOUS APPOINTMENTS

Short Term Consultant *World Bank (TTL Sydney Gourlay)* Mar 2025 - June 2025

Research Assistant *for Prof. Karen Macours (PSE)* July 2022 - Aug 2022

Pre-doctoral Fellow *Research Assistant for Prof. Karen Macours (PSE)/ SPIA-CGIAR* Sep 2020 - Sep 2021

Consultant *Inter-American Development Bank (IADB)* Oct 2019 - May 2020

Junior Researcher *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)* Aug 2016 - Jun 2018

Assistant Editor **LAJED Journal** *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)* Aug 2016 - Jun 2018

Research Assistant *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)* Feb 2014 - Jul 2016

AFFILIATIONS

American Economic Association (AEA), European Economic Association (EEA), Latin American and Caribbean Economic Association (LACEA), Association Française d'Économie du Développement (AFEDEV), Association Française des Économistes de la Population (AFÉPOP), Elected member of the directors' board at the Bolivian Society of Economists (SEBOL) 2024-2026.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Referee: Journal of Development Economics, Latin American Journal of Economic Development (LAJED), EAYE Annual Meeting 2026, Bolivian Conference on Development Economics 2026.

Seminar and conference organization: Development Economics Seminar, Paris School of Economics, 2024-2025; Bolivian Conference on Development Economics (BCDE), 2024 and 2025.

Mentoring: EconThaki, 2024.

OTHER INFORMATION

Programming: Stata, R, Python, L^AT_EX, ArcGIS/QGIS.

Languages: Spanish (native), English (advanced), French (intermediate).

REFERENCES

Karen Macours
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Matthew Gordon
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✉ matthew.gordon@psemail.eu